Glossary of Key Terms: The Psychopathology of Everyday Things

Discoverability

The ability of a design to help users figure out what actions are possible and where to perform them.

Example:
A clearly visible "Print" button on a printing kiosk makes printing discoverable.

Understanding

The ability of users to understand what a product does and how to use it.

Example:
A button labeled "Pay Now" is easier to understand than a button with an unclear symbol.

Affordance

The relationship between an object's properties and a person's abilities that makes certain actions possible. An affordance is what an object allows someone to do.

Examples:

- A chair affords sitting.
- A button affords clicking.
- A handle affords pulling.

Important Idea

Affordances depend on:

1. The object
2. The user

For example:

- A heavy chair may be liftable by a strong person but not by a child.

Perceivable Affordance

An affordance that users can easily notice. Users can clearly see what actions are possible.

Example:
A raised button on a screen looks clickable.

Anti-Affordance

A feature that prevents an action from occurring.

Example:
Glass allows you to see through it but prevents you from walking through it.

Hidden Affordance

An affordance that exists but is not obvious to users. The action is possible, but users may not know it.

Examples:

- Keyboard shortcuts
- Hidden menus in mobile apps
- Secret compartments in furniture

False Affordance

When an object looks like it allows an action but actually does not. The design misleads users.

Examples:

- A button that looks clickable but does nothing
- Underlined text that is not a link
- Decorative drawers that cannot open

Signifier

Any visible, audible, or perceivable clue that tells people how to use something.

Examples:

- A "PULL" sign on a door
- A search icon (magnifying glass)
- An arrow showing which way to swipe

Explicit Signifier

A signifier that clearly tells users what to do.

Example:
A door labeled "PULL."

Perceivable Signifier

A signifier that users can easily notice and understand.

Example:
A brightly colored button that stands out from the rest of the interface.

Affordances vs Signifiers

Affordance

Answers:

"What actions are possible?"

Signifier

Answers:

"Where and how should I perform the action?"

Signifiers reveal affordances and reduce trial and error.

Example:

- Door handle = affordance (can be pulled)
- "PULL" label = signifier (tells you to pull)

Mapping

The relationship between controls and the things they control.

Examples:

- Steering wheel turns the car in the same direction.
- Volume slider moved up increases volume.

Natural Mapping

A mapping relationship that feels obvious and natural to users. Users can predict what will happen without instructions.

Examples:

- Turning a stove knob near a burner controls that burner.
- A seat-shaped control adjusts the matching part of a car seat.

Cultural Mapping

Mapping that depends on cultural expectations. What feels natural in one culture may not feel natural in another.

Example:
Different cultures may expect scrolling up or down to move to the next item.

Feedback

Information that communicates the result of an action.

Examples:

- A message saying "File Uploaded"
- A beep after pressing a button
- A loading animation

Haptic Feedback

Feedback provided through touch or vibration.

Example:
A smartphone vibration when a key is pressed.

Immediate Feedback

Feedback that occurs as soon as an action is performed.

Example:
A button changes color immediately after being clicked.

Informative Feedback

Feedback that clearly explains what happened.

Example:
Instead of a random beep, the system displays:

"Payment Successful"

Unobtrusive Feedback

Feedback that informs users without distracting them.

Example:
A small status message appearing quietly in a corner.

Conceptual Model

A simplified explanation of how something works.

Example:
Many people think of computer folders as physical folders that hold documents.

System Image

Everything users see and experience that helps them form a conceptual model.

Includes:

- Physical appearance
- Affordances
- Signifiers
- Mapping
- Feedback
- Previous experience

Example:
A printer's buttons, display screen, and status messages together create the user's understanding of how the printer works.

7. General Design Concepts

Object

The thing being interacted with.

Examples:

- Door
- Chair

- Mobile app
- Printing kiosk

Action

Something a user can do with an object.

Examples:

- Push a door
- Click a button
- Print a document

State

The current condition of an object.

Examples:

- Door is open
- Door is closed
- Printer is printing
- Printer is idle